

FILM PREVIEW

THE PRESIDENT IS COMING

Nasty, but Nice

Director: Kunaal Roy Kapur
Starring: Konkona Sen Sharma, Shernaz Patel, Ira Dubey

Sri Sri Ravi Shankar, says one. No, no, Osho, shouts another. This is the round on *Recognising American Faces*. One mistakes Colin Powell for Nelson Mandela and another declares Manoj Night Shyamalan is Mahesh Bhupathi. These are only some of the funny moments in Anuvab Pal's hilarious *The President is Coming*, which is the most good-natured evisceration

of both George W. Bush and India's obsession with America, that has been made. Pal, who wrote the equally ironic *Loins of Punjab Presents*, scripts a reality show where one among six young Indians has to be chosen to shake Bush's hand when he comes to India. Sen Sharma, as a radical novelist who has written *Some Yellow Mangoes* and *12 Broken Dreams*, is a hoot, as is Ira Dubey playing a spoilt princess who started a cosmetics "empire" with Daddy's Rs 3 crore and now has a turnover of Rs 5 crore. A confused call centre exec whose job involves cutting out "native tongue interference", a Hindutva-obsessed Hindi-speaking social service worker, a kleptomaniac PR boss and a chaotic embassy where Dharmendra's portrait is made to pass off as George W. Bush Sr. This is a nasty, but nice movie that's a perfect send-off for the outgoing President. And this is not even counting a delicious interlude where all six contestants are made to recite Bush "speeches". Such gems as "is our children learning?" and "Singapore is the capital of Asia" almost make you want to break out into a love poem like the venerable Manmohan Singh. What ever will the world do without W?

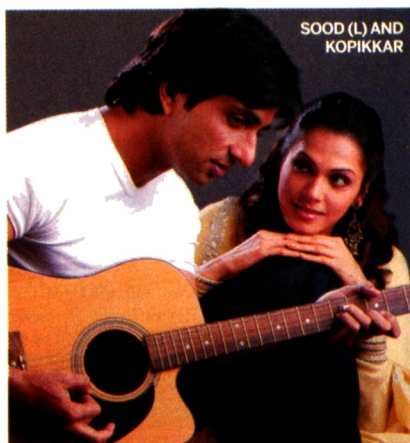
by Kaveree Bamzai

RATING ★ ★ ★ ☆ ☆

FILM REVIEW

EK VIVA AH... AISABHI

The Weep Stakes



Director: Kaushik Ghatak
Starring: Sonu Sood, Isha Kopikkar

This is the kind of film where everyone has parathas for breakfast, carries ladoos on train journeys, listens to music on cassettes and is excited when they buy a Kinetic scooter. It's Little India, with its made-to-measure lives, where duty is not to be shirked and families are not to be divided, where men and women holding hands is the height of intimacy (huh?) and where music and food are interchangeably important. A young singer loses her father, then chooses to bring up her younger brother and sister, putting her own marriage on hold. Kopikkar dimples too much and tosses her head like a horse in trauma but is restrained when she has to shoulder the family burden. Sood is low-key as the suitor who loves in silence and sings endlessly. The moral science lessons are as frequent as the songs, but there is a subtle emotion here that has you weeping silently into your dupatta or pallu as the case may be. This is Ram Rajya, Barjatya style, where you feel good by feeling bad. Truly the family that weeps together always keeps together.

-KB

RATING ★ ★ ★ ☆ ☆